they came forward, he asked on the mike, ‘When was ration card issuance done here in this village?’ The DM, the highest-ranked official in the district, whispered an answer to the chief minister, who then made another announcement: ‘Organise a camp in the village tomorrow itself and give out ration cards here as per eligibility.’ There was loud applause from the crowd. ‘Within a week, make sure this is done across the entire panchayat so ration cards under Antyodaya [a Union government scheme] and Paatra Grahasthi [a state government scheme] are all given out as per eligibility.’

One by one, he read out the names of government schemes in operation in the village, got officers to list out the names of beneficiaries from government lists, personally read out some of these lists and asked villagers to tally them with their own experience. How many water handpumps had been reported broken in the village? How many had been repaired? When? How many Nirashrit Mahilas, destitute women, were getting government pensions? (Seventy-five, with thirty more names sanctioned in the new year.) How many Divyang, differently abled, pensions? (Sixty-five, and seventeen new ones sanctioned.) In each case, figures and names were read out from government lists, villagers were asked to verify them, vigorous debates ensued between those who felt they had been wrongly left out and the officials present, and the latter were asked to resolve the matter.

The audience’s most vigorous reaction came when Yogi Adityanath asked about the Pradhan Mantri Awas Yojana, the Union government’s scheme for housing for the poor. A man in a saffron scarf, sitting on an overlooking tree, shouted that he had been left out. The chief minister invited him onstage—‘Say it from here on the mike and on stage’—to loud cheers from the crowd.

‘I had filled a form,’ complained the saffron-scarf man, now standing on stage and looking him in the eye, ‘but didn’t get anything.’

‘Just filling up a form won’t do it,’ responded Yogi, as the public gathering threatened to get out of control. ‘Labharthee names on the list are decided according to eligibility criteria set by the 2011 Socio-Economic Survey Report,’ he explained. ‘Selection is done only on that basis. Neither the DPRO nor the Gram Pradhan [Village Head]